

houses. The film has made Rs 4.3 crore in three weeks since its release.

Happy tidings for Marathi cinema began in 2004 with *Shwaas* being sent as India's official entry to the 77th Academy Awards. Its success was followed by Nishikant Kamat's *Dombivli Fast*, which won a Grand Jury Prize at the fourth Indian Film Festival of Los Angeles.

The nurturing ground of legends like V. Shantaram and Dadasaheb Phalke, Marathi cinema lost its way trying to fit into the Bollywood formula. The last five years have been different. Throwing out rural sagas and domestic dramas, young filmmakers now are exploring new themes and creating success stories. "These films are rooted in culture, yet contemporary, and that's what makes them so appealing," says Umesh Kulkarni, 30, director of *Valu*, one of the most successful films last year. It won rave reviews at the Rotterdam and Warsaw film festivals. Set in a village near Pune, the film is refreshing and the raw dialect adds to the effect. Getting a producer wasn't easy though and Kulkarni raised Rs 1 crore from friends. "Producers weren't willing to go beyond the usual slapstick fare and experiment with new subjects," says the Film and Television Institute of India graduate who is now working on more scripts.

Mangesh Hadale's *Tingya*, based on the relationship between a young boy and a bull, ran to a full house in Mumbai's Plaza theatre for a week after its release in March this year and raked in four times its production cost of Rs 48 lakh. "The

BHASKAR PAUL



SHREYAS TALPADE,

32, ACTOR

Despite his new-found Bollywood fame, he is producing Marathi film *Sanai Chougade*

film is not restricted to Marathi culture. It is a universal theme, which transcends language barriers," says the 27-year-old debutant from a family of farmers. Hadale approached 41 producers with his script before Ravi Rai financed it. "I was told to include an item number or take big names but I refused to budge," says the arts graduate from Pune. Basking in the success of his debut film, Hadale will soon be off to the US to shoot a Hinglish film, *Package India*.

While some continue to experiment with rustic settings, for most contemporary directors, urban films, animation and social commentaries are the new success mantras. The rising budgets are also giving Marathi films a makeover. For instance, based on a 17th century shield, Aditya Sarpotdar's *Uladhaal* has been shot at 104 locations and is loaded with animation and graphics, at a whopping Rs 2.75 crore, making it the most expensive Marathi film ever. "The youth, whether urban or rural, wants fun, adventure-filled films," says

the 23-year-old first-time director. In yet another 'first' for Marathi cinema, Sarpotdar will release his film's music at a grand event next month and is shooting a promotional video

with Bollywood director Mahesh Manjrekar. Compare this with *Shwaas* four years ago. The producers had to stage a fund raising rally to collect money to take the film to the Oscars.

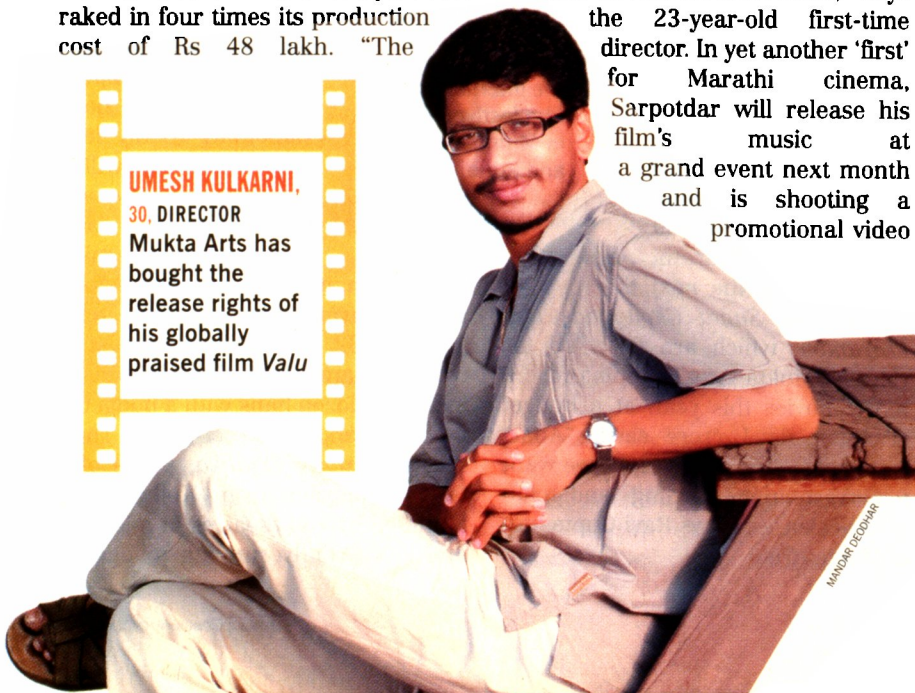
New scripts and superior technology notwithstanding, a spurt in the number of regional channels and the presence of multiplexes in smaller towns are also giving Marathi cinema a much-needed boost. The growth of digital distribution has deepened the penetration of cinema. Films, which were earlier released on 15 screens, are now digitally released simultaneously in over 70 theatres across Maharashtra. "Digital releases ensure a bigger collection for producers, who can then put more money into their next production," says Sanjay Gaikwad, founder and CEO of UFO Moviez.

The growing size of the Indian entertainment industry is also prompting producers to target regional cinema, considered a comparatively low risk venture. "You can produce three Marathi films with the amount you would spend on one Hindi movie. Because of low budgets you recover money faster," says Girish Wankhede, who introduced Marathi film festivals at Cinemax theatres. Akhil Bharatiya Marathi Chitrapat Mahamandal President Ajay Sarpotdar claims that the industry's box-office revenue has jumped from Rs 4 crore in 2006 to Rs 25 crore in 2007. "The figure will go up further this year as we expect over 80 films to release as against 60 last year," he says. With contemporary themes, global recognition and young blood inducing verve, it may not be long before Marathi cinema gets a second chance at the Oscars.

UMESH KULKARNI,

30, DIRECTOR

Mukta Arts has bought the release rights of his globally praised film *Valu*



MANOJ DEODHAR